

The Earth's atmosphere

The atmosphere is a blanket of gases that surrounds and protects the Earth. It keeps us warm, blocks some of the Sun's harmful rays, and helps stop space rocks from hitting us.

Auroras

These dazzling coloured lights dance in the night sky in places close to the North and South Poles. They are also called the northern and southern lights.



Auroras happen when tiny particles from the Sun hit particles in our atmosphere.

Meteorites

Space rocks that make it through our atmosphere and hit the ground without burning up are called meteorites.

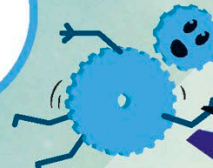
Weather balloon



Launched every day, weather balloons help forecasters predict the weather. The balloons carry small tools to measure things, such as air temperature and wind speed.

Aeroplanes

Planes usually cruise at about 9–12 km (6–8 miles) high. There are often strong winds at these heights, which can make flights turbulent, or bumpy.



Planes fly high up, where the air is thinner. This means they can travel easier and faster, and burn less fuel.